If

you ever spot sitar maestro Purbayan Chatterjee on a flight, deeply immersed in listening to his headphones and staring out the window, you might think he is simply unwinding between gruelling performance schedules. In reality, he is working his second job—being a "good thief". Borrowing a piece of advice from his close friend and mentor, jazz icon Ranjit Barot, who once told him, "You are a good artist when you are a good thief," Chatterjee spends his travel hours listening to everything from John Mayer and Miles Davis to Taylor Swift and progressive metal. No, he isn't looking to plagiarise a melody; he is looking for an idea or a philosophy that inspires him enough to weave it into his classical performances.

This uninhibited willingness to learn other musical languages is precisely what has made the 49-year-old one of the most exciting, genre-defying forces on the global stage today. It is a mindset that beautifully sets the stage for an incredibly ambitious season ahead. This summer, the sitar virtuoso is living out his philosophy in two deeply interconnected ways—first, by embarking on a six-city India tour alongside long-time collaborator flutist Rakesh Chaurasia; and second, by dropping his cross-cultural album, *Feathered Creatures*, a striking dialogue with Grammy-winning American guitarist Mark Lettieri of Snarky Puppy.

"Rakeshbhai and I made an album called *Saath Saath* in 2022 and toured with it in the US and UK. We have been doing *jugalbandi* for the past three decades now and we wanted to celebrate this long partnership with a tour," he shares. The *Saath Saath* six-city tour, starting from May 30, will see the duo perform in Kolkata, Delhi, Surat, Nagpur, Chennai and Mumbai. As for the new album with Lettieri, Chatterjee shares that its foundation lies in the friendship and bonhomie he enjoys with the acclaimed guitarist and their shared curiosity for strings. They didn't rush the album—over the course of three years, they meticulously sculpted, layered and stripped back sounds to create *Feathered Creatures*. Their organic camaraderie is the secret sauce behind how an Indian sitar and an American electric guitar strike a delicate, ego-free balance without overpowering one another.

Collaborations, Chatterjee believes, are all about venturing into the world. "For any artist, there are two crucial dimensions to your identity—where you are coming from, and where you are going," he says, adding that the beautiful irony is that the deeper your understanding of your roots, the more effectively you can navigate where you want to go. "But it also works in reverse. The more courageously you venture out into new territories without inhibition, the better you ultimately understand your own origins," he adds.

The torchbearer of the Senia Maihar Gharana was just 15 years old when he received the President of India Award for Best Instrumentalist. As he candidly recalls, his teenage self was mostly thinking—"The food is going to be great at home tonight, my peers are going to look at me differently, and the girls are definitely going to give me a lot of attention!" The euphoria lasted for a couple of days. What kept him grounded was the advice he received from his father and guru, sitarist Pandit Parthapratim Chatterjee. "He told me to be very happy today and forget about it tomorrow," recalls Chatterjee.

That foundational grounding



CHATTERJEE IS ALSO **WORKING CLOSELY WITH ACTOR FARHAN AKHTAR** FOR HIS HOLLYWOOD DEBUT IN THE BEATLES BIOPIC WHERE AKHTAR PORTRAYS THE SITAR MAESTRO PANDIT RAVI SHANKAR